

4. Copyists would often give expression to an artistic bent with the top line of a page and the end of lines, using flourishes, curlicues, exaggerated forms, lines running off the page, and such—these should be ignored.
5. Alternate spellings of the same word, where the identity of the word and its meaning are not touched. This one is a bit more bothersome than the others, but I think it should be included in the list. However, such differences can be useful in identifying sub-groups. I include here alternate spellings of a transliterated foreign word, as in Mark 5:41 (the more so, in this case, since it is translated).
6. Where the order of words is changed, but that change does not affect the meaning in any way (apparently), they are two ways of saying the same thing. Such are not ‘proper’ variants, although they may be useful in identifying subgroups. Some changes in word order do affect the nuance, so each case needs to be evaluated individually. For example: in Luke 10:41, is it ο Ιησους ειπεν αυτη, or is it ειπεν αυτη ο Ιησους? Both mean simply “Jesus said to her”.

I am changing the way I describe the performance of MSS with reference to their archetype. A MS that reproduces the archetypal form without any variants is a copy that represents the archetype perfectly. A MS that has only different ways of saying the same thing is a copy that represents the archetype completely. In this second category I include MSS that have only alternate forms and/or corrections to the archetypal form—the true reading is preserved in every case. I also include here the repeating of a letter or syllable going from one line to the next (not a ‘proper’ variant in any case).

Of course, when printing a text a choice must be made between competing forms [I am prepared to explain mine in every case], but since the meaning is not touched, such choices will mainly be of concern to someone wishing to apply a numeric code to the text. **The sort of changes listed above may not legitimately be used to argue against the doctrine of inerrancy.**

Collated f³⁵ Manuscripts¹

When I say that a MS had a perfect exemplar (a perfect copy of the family archetype), I did not charge what appear to be a copy’s private errors to its exemplar—that includes corrections to the archetype. Of course my judgment is presumed, of necessity, since I have no way of knowing

¹ This was the situation in January, 2020.